STATE SCAN

GOA: A GOAN RECIPE FOR TROUBLE *PG 18*
TAMIL NADU: NEW ROLE FOR HAASAN *PG 20*



THE TRIUMVIRATE
Eknath Shinde with Devendra Fadnavis and Ajit Pawar at a press conference, October 2024

MILIND SHELTE

▶ MAHARASHTRA

SHINDE LOSES SHINE

The ex-CM is besieged within the Mahayuti—Ajit snipes at his Sena, as BJP offers cover fire. Will they fight polls separately?

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

IF YOU'VE SEEN THOSE animated 'bar chart races', rankings that keep shifting to capture a competition across time, it's a perfect fit for Maharashtra's ruling trinity. Devendra Fadnavis ahead till mid-2022, Eknath Shinde shooting up, then Ajit Pawar threatening to crash the party, and so on. Except that, after the first pocketed the CM's post last December, Shinde's bar has been a bit sluggish and angry.

Fadnavis had once called Shinde a "natural ally", and Ajit a mere "political ally", implying the NCP (Nationalist Congress Party) was an unpleasant necessity. But of late, the BJP's affections have turned. The ideological buddy, who resaffronised a chunk of the Shiv Sena, seems marginalised in the Mahayuti. Ajit is executing a slow demolition job on his fellow deputy CM, digging in a jack here, dangling a counterweight there, all with the BJP watching from the sidelines.

SNIP, SNIP

For one, as FM, Ajit is merrily trimming allocations to Sena ministries. Moreover, the political defections he's been effecting from his parent party, the NCP(SCP), seem engineered to corner Sena biggies on their home turf—from Jalgaon in the north, Kolhapur in the south to Mahad on the coast.

Shinde's been returning the compliment, lassoing in worthies from Congress, BJP, Sena (UBT) and NCP(SCP): one meant to harass NCP veteran Chhagan Bhujbal in Nashik,